

are aligned with ambition, a single generation can transform a nation.

Failures and warnings

Not all nations sustain their rise. Argentina, Brazil, and the Soviet Union show how corruption, policy instability, and weak market alignment can derail progress. Ambition without governance collapses, and education without innovation stagnates.

Why India is positioned to lead.

India is not at the margins. It is already in the race (Fig. 1). Today, it is among the five largest economies and is projected to surpass Japan and Germany in the near term.

Demographics. By 2040, India will have the world's largest working age population, while many competitors age. Presently India has a large pool of young population, which it must enable (See Table 1). We must produce what the world wants to buy from us. There is a huge opportunity (See Fig. 3).

Digital public infrastructure.

Aadhaar, UPI, CoWIN, and India Stack show India can deliver population scale systems. (See Fig. 2 for how the internet users have grown

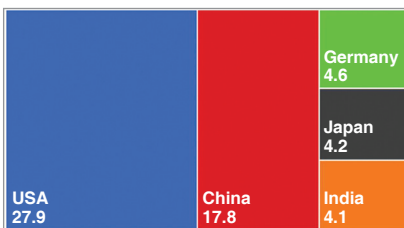


Fig. 1: GDP in US\$ trillions (Nominal, 2024 est.) (Source: IMF World Economic Outlook, April 2024)

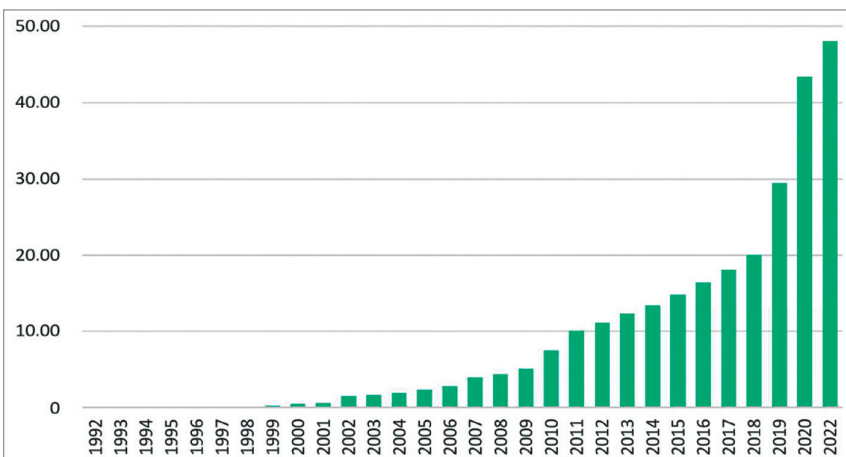


Fig. 2: Percentage of individuals using the internet (Source: United Nations Statistics Division)

in India.) UPI alone handles billions of monthly transactions.

Global talent. Indians lead major technology companies and research labs. The diaspora thrives in Silicon Valley and other hubs.

Entrepreneurship. With more than a hundred unicorns, India has one of the largest startup ecosystems. It is still skewed to services, yet fertile ground exists for deep technology.

These are raw ingredients. The challenge is to align them into a coherent national mission.

The risks of falling short

The risks are real. India could falter if it does not confront systemic barriers.

Corruption and black money.

Distorted incentives reward influence over ideas and choke innovation.

Infrastructure gaps.

Power outages, congested roads, and unreliable logistics reduce competitiveness.

Educational disparity.

Too many children complete primary school without basic literacy or numeracy. This is a national emergency.

Innovation bottlenecks. Current patent interpretation excludes software as such, which limits defensible intellectual property.

According to NITI Aayog, India's R&D spending has hovered at a mere 0.7% of GDP, and far below peers like China or Israel (Fig. 4).

Without correction, India risks becoming a perpetual services provider rather than a leader that shapes global technology and trade.

From The Editor

At Electronics For You, our mission has always been to make technology accessible, relevant, and actionable for every Indian. Technology has reshaped industries, created opportunities, and opened doors that once seemed closed. Much remains to be done for India to claim its place atop world economy.

With this issue, we proudly introduce a landmark series: "India's Path to #1 Economy," authored by Janardhana Swamy. We invite you to read, reflect, and respond. India's journey to becoming number one is a mission for all of us.

Rahul Chopra
Editor,
ElectronicsForU.com Network

TABLE 1
DEMOGRAPHIC PROFILE –
INDIA VS PEERS (2024)

Country	Median Age	Working-Age Pop. %	Dependency Ratio
India	28	67%	0.5
China	39	61%	0.6
USA	38	65%	0.5
Japan	49	56%	0.7

(Source: United Nations World Population Prospects 2024)

The education imperative.

Economic leadership begins in classrooms. Nations do not innovate when their children cannot read, calculate, or ask questions with confidence.

A diode behaves the same everywhere, but its teaching differs widely between a top laboratory and a small town college classroom. India must embrace One Nation, One Education so that opportunity is not defined by geography. Standardised quality, bilingual fluency, and a national Mission Maths must become non-negotiable.

Aligning innovation and integrity

For India, the choice is distinct: remain a large emerging economy, or step into its rightful place as the world's foremost economic power by 2040. This is not only about pride or rankings. It is about survival, sovereignty, and responsibility.

Unless reformed, India will lose not for lack of talent, but for lack of foresight. The paradox is striking.